

What is Positive Behaviour Support? A plain-English guide for parents

By Paula Gillespie, Specialist Positive Behaviour Support Practitioner · August 2026
· 6 minute read

If someone has just suggested "behaviour support" for your child, you probably have two feelings at once: relief that help exists, and worry about what it says about your child and your parenting. This guide explains what Positive Behaviour Support actually is, in the language we use with families, not the language of reports.

The short answer

Positive Behaviour Support, usually shortened to PBS, is an evidence-based way of helping children whose behaviour has become distressing, unsafe or exhausting for them and the people around them. It works by understanding *why* the behaviour happens, then changing the world around the child so the hard moments happen less often, while teaching the child easier ways to communicate and cope.

Two things make PBS different from what many families have already tried. First, it is not about punishment or consequences. Second, it does not treat your child as the problem to be fixed. The focus is on environments, routines, relationships and skills, and on improving quality of life for your child and your whole family.

Behaviour is communication

The idea at the heart of PBS is simple to say and takes practice to live: behaviour is communication. A child who lashes out, runs, shuts down or melts down is telling us something they cannot yet say another way. It might be "this is too loud", "I don't understand what happens next", "I need you", or "something hurts".

When adults learn to read the message, everything changes. The question stops being "how do we stop this behaviour?" and becomes "what is this behaviour doing for our child, and how do we give them a better way to get the same need met?"

What does "behaviours of concern" mean?

You will hear professionals say "behaviours of concern" rather than "bad behaviour" or "challenging behaviour". That wording is deliberate. It describes behaviours that put someone's safety, learning, relationships or quality of life at risk, things like self-injury, aggression, absconding or severe meltdowns, without blaming the child for them. A behaviour of concern is a signal that a need is not being met, not a character flaw.

What actually happens? The five stages

At AkindaCo, PBS runs through five stages over several months. In brief:

1. **Getting to know you.** A relaxed 90-minute session with you and the people who know your child best.
2. **Understanding the behaviour.** A Functional Behaviour Assessment: looking closely at what happens before, during and after the hard moments in real settings.
3. **A written plan.** A practical Behaviour Support Plan in plain language: ways to prevent stress building, skills to teach, and clear steps for responding.
4. **Putting it into action.** Coaching for you and your child's team until the strategies work in everyday life.
5. **Review.** Every three to six months we look at what has changed, celebrate progress and set new goals.

There's a fuller description of each stage on our [main PBS page](#).

What does "multi-element" mean?

AkindaCo practises within the Multi-Element Behaviour Support framework, often shortened to MEBS. In practice it means the plan never rests on one trick. It works on several elements at once: the physical environment, routines and predictability, relationships, new skills for your child, and clear, agreed ways for adults to respond. Real change usually needs several small changes working together, not one big one.

What PBS is not

- **It is not a quick fix.** A typical PBS engagement runs across months, because real change means changing environments, skills and habits, not just writing a document.
- **It is not about blame.** Behaviours of concern are nobody's fault, not your child's and not yours.
- **It is not just a report.** A plan that sits in a drawer changes nothing. The coaching and follow-through are where the work happens.
- **It is not only for children with a diagnosis.** Autistic and ADHD children, children with developmental delay, children who have experienced trauma, and children with no diagnosis at all can all benefit.

How is PBS funded?

For most families, PBS is funded through the Improved Relationships part of their child's NDIS plan, shown as "Behaviour Support" or "CB Relationships" in PACE plans. The 2026–27 NDIS price limit is \$252.99 per hour, and invoices usually go straight to the NDIA or your plan manager. Some of the work happens away from sessions, like analysing observations and writing the plan, and that non-face-to-face time is part of the funded hours. Privately funded families are welcome too. The full details, including the line item and how billing works, are on our [funding page](#).

How do I start?

Start with a conversation. At AkindaCo the first 15-minute phone call is free: you tell us what has been happening, and we tell you honestly whether PBS is the right fit and what it would involve. We support families across Salisbury, North Adelaide and the wider Adelaide area, at home, at school, online and in clinic.

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